ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Obligation, permission and necessity

Distinguish internal and external obligation, absence of necessity, prohibition and formal permission across time. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use obligation, permission and necessity to state rules and choices without confusing not necessary with not allowed while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Distinguish internal and external obligation, absence of necessity, prohibition and formal permission across time.

MODEL

You do not have to attend, but you must submit the form.

must / have to / need to | do not have to | must not | may

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main obligation, permission and necessity patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses state rules and choices without confusing not necessary with not allowed.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in workplace policy, instructions, advice and formal communication.

Build meaning before form

Distinguish internal and external obligation, absence of necessity, prohibition and formal permission across time.

What obligation, permission and necessity communicates

Distinguish internal and external obligation, absence of necessity, prohibition and formal permission across time.

The central purpose is to state rules and choices without confusing not necessary with not allowed. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

All visitors have to show identification.	an obligation imposed by a rule or situation
You do not have to attend the optional session.	an action that is permitted but not required
Staff must not share customer passwords.	an action that is explicitly forbidden

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: must / have to / need to | do not have to | must not | may. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “You do not have to attend, but you must submit the form.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Required action	must / have to + base	All visitors have to show identification.
No necessity	do not have to / need not + base	You do not have to attend the optional session.
Prohibition	must not / may not + base	Staff must not share customer passwords.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
an obligation imposed by a rule or situation	Required action
an action that is permitted but not required	No necessity
an action that is explicitly forbidden	Prohibition

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in workplace policy, instructions, advice and formal communication. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
must / have to / need to	do not have to	must not	may

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: state rules and choices without confusing not necessary with not allowed.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits workplace policy, instructions, advice and formal communication.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Required action	must / have to + base	All visitors have to show identification.
No necessity	do not have to / need not + base	You do not have to attend the optional session.
Prohibition	must not / may not + base	Staff must not share customer passwords.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

All visitors have to show identification.	an obligation imposed by a rule or situation
You do not have to attend the optional session.	an action that is permitted but not required
Staff must not share customer passwords.	an action that is explicitly forbidden

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not assume must and have to always carry identical source and tone.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not confuse do not have to with must not.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use do not have to when the action is forbidden.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an obligation imposed by a rule or situation?

OPTIONS All visitors have to show identification. · You do not have to attend the optional session. · Staff must not share customer passwords.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an action that is permitted but not required?

OPTIONS You do not have to attend the optional session. · Staff must not share customer passwords. · All visitors have to show identification.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an action that is explicitly forbidden?

OPTIONS Staff must not share customer passwords. · All visitors have to show identification. · You do not have to attend the optional session.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “All visitors have to show identification.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an obligation imposed by a rule or situation · an action that is permitted but not required · an action that is explicitly forbidden

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “You do not have to attend the optional session.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an action that is permitted but not required · an action that is explicitly forbidden · an obligation imposed by a rule or situation

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Staff must not share customer passwords.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an action that is explicitly forbidden · an obligation imposed by a rule or situation · an action that is permitted but not required

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“All visitors have to show identification.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Required action / No necessity / Prohibition · Gap 2: an obligation imposed by a rule or situation / an action that is permitted but not required / an action that is explicitly forbidden

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“You do not have to attend the optional session.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: No necessity / Prohibition / Required action · Gap 2: an action that is permitted but not required / an action that is explicitly forbidden / an obligation imposed by a rule or situation

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“Staff must not share customer passwords.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Prohibition / Required action / No necessity · Gap 2: an action that is explicitly forbidden / an obligation imposed by a rule or situation / an action that is permitted but not required

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses an obligation imposed by a rule or situation: _____. Choose the model that expresses an action that is permitted but not required: _____. Choose the model that expresses an action that is explicitly forbidden: _____. Choose the model built with must / have to + base: _____. Choose the model built with do not have to / need not + base: _____. Choose the model built with must not / may not + base: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

All visitors have to show identification. · Staff must not share customer passwords. · You do not have to attend the optional session.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

All visitors _____ identification. You _____ the optional session. Staff _____ customer passwords. State the full structural pattern for Required action: _____. State the full structural pattern for No necessity: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The rule requires every visitor to show ID.” using the Required action pattern to express an obligation imposed by a rule or situation.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Attendance is optional.” using the No necessity pattern to express an action that is permitted but not required.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Sharing passwords is prohibited.” using the Prohibition pattern to express an action that is explicitly forbidden.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The rule requires every visitor to show ID.” using the Required action pattern to express an obligation imposed by a rule or situation.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Required action to express an obligation imposed by a rule or situation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use No necessity to express an action that is permitted but not required, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Prohibition to express an action that is explicitly forbidden, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

All visitors have to show identification.

Required action is the best match because an obligation imposed by a rule or situation.

A2

You do not have to attend the optional session.

No necessity is the best match because an action that is permitted but not required.

A3

Staff must not share customer passwords.

Prohibition is the best match because an action that is explicitly forbidden.

A4

an obligation imposed by a rule or situation

The Required action pattern communicates an obligation imposed by a rule or situation.

A5

an action that is permitted but not required

The No necessity pattern communicates an action that is permitted but not required.

A6

an action that is explicitly forbidden

The Prohibition pattern communicates an action that is explicitly forbidden.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Required action / an obligation imposed by a rule or situation

The structure belongs to the Required action pattern. Its communicative purpose is an obligation imposed by a rule or situation.

B2

No necessity / an action that is permitted but not required

The structure belongs to the No necessity pattern. Its communicative purpose is an action that is permitted but not required.

B3

Prohibition / an action that is explicitly forbidden

The structure belongs to the Prohibition pattern. Its communicative purpose is an action that is explicitly forbidden.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

All visitors have to show identification.

Required action: must / have to + base.

C2

You do not have to attend the optional session.

No necessity: do not have to / need not + base.

C3

Staff must not share customer passwords.

Prohibition: must not / may not + base.

C4

All visitors have to show identification.

Required action: must / have to + base.

C5

You do not have to attend the optional session.

No necessity: do not have to / need not + base.

C6

Staff must not share customer passwords.

Prohibition: must not / may not + base.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

have to show

Required action requires “have to show” in this model. must / have to + base.

D2

do not have to attend

No necessity requires “do not have to attend” in this model. do not have to / need not + base.

D3

must not share

Prohibition requires “must not share” in this model. must not / may not + base.

D4

must / have to + base

Required action is built as must / have to + base.

D5

do not have to / need not + base

No necessity is built as do not have to / need not + base.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

All visitors have to show identification.

must / have to + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended required action effect.

E2

You do not have to attend the optional session.

do not have to / need not + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended no necessity effect.

E3

Staff must not share customer passwords.

must not / may not + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended prohibition effect.

E4

All visitors have to show identification.

must / have to + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended required action effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

All visitors have to show identification. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses must / have to + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

You do not have to attend the optional session. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses do not have to / need not + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Staff must not share customer passwords. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses must not / may not + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____